GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution

Ensuring Food Security and Consumer Empowerment

Confidential and Proprietory
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HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA



MESSAGE

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HONORABLE MINISTER,
MINISTRY OF CONSUMER AFFAIRS,
FOOD AND PUBLIC DISTRIBUTION



MESSAGE

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MESSAGE

Ensuring consumer protection, food security, transparent markets, and efficient public distribution systems remains fundamental to India's inclusive development agenda. The Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution plays a critical role in safeguarding consumer rights, strengthening supply chains, maintaining food security, and promoting fair trade practices while ensuring equitable access to essential commodities.

The Chamber of Commerce and Industries of India (CCI India) is committed to supporting the Ministry through collaborative initiatives that strengthen supply chain efficiency, encourage digital innovation, improve consumer awareness, facilitate private sector participation, and promote sustainable market practices. By bringing together industry, policymakers, technology providers, startups, cooperatives, and research institutions, CCI India seeks to contribute towards building a more resilient and transparent consumer ecosystem.

This Knowledge Paper provides comprehensive insights into the Ministry's policy initiatives, regulatory framework, food security mechanisms, consumer protection strategies, digital transformation initiatives, and emerging opportunities for public-private collaboration. It highlights innovative approaches in supply chain modernization, warehousing, food logistics, digital grievance redressal, smart public distribution systems, quality assurance, and consumer empowerment.

The publication is intended to serve as a strategic reference for policymakers, government departments, industry stakeholders, investors, entrepreneurs, technology companies, cooperatives, development organizations, and academic institutions. Through informed dialogue and collaborative engagement, it seeks to promote transparency, efficiency, innovation, and inclusive growth across India's consumer and food distribution ecosystem.

As India continues to strengthen its food security framework and consumer protection systems, partnerships across sectors will play an increasingly important role. CCI India remains dedicated to supporting the Ministry in advancing efficient governance, sustainable development, and consumer-centric reforms.

Munindra Kumar
Director General
CCI India

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PREFACE

The Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution (MoCAFPD) occupies a foundational position in India's socio-economic architecture. Its dual mandate to protect the rights of 1.4 billion consumers and to ensure food security for the nation's most vulnerable populations places it at the interof economic governance, social welfare, and national resilience. As India accelerates towards its Viksit Bharat 2047 vision, the role of this Ministry becomes even more critical, requiring not just administrative efficiency but strategic co-creation with industry, civil society, and knowledge institutions.

India's consumer market is on the cusp of a historic transformation. With a projected GDP of USD 7 trillion by 2030 and a consuming class expected to reach 850 million by 2027, the governance frameworks for consumer protection, food distribution, and commodity regulation must evolve commensurately. The Ministry is navigating this transition while simultaneously managing legacy public distribution infrastructure, emerging e-commerce regulations, and the digital disruption of traditional retail markets.

This Knowledge Paper has been prepared by CCI India the Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India as a strategic advisory document to map the Ministry's mandate, assess systemic opportunities, and propose a structured, time-bound collaboration framework. This document is informed by publicly available data, policy documents, budget analyses, and sector-level intelligence.

CCI India's vision is to serve as a bridge between government policy and industry execution facilitating investment, enabling startups, building institutional capacity, and driving evidence-based policy advocacy. This paper represents CCI India's commitment to that vision in the specific context of consumer welfare, food systems, and public distribution reforms.

This document is intended for the review of Union Ministers, Secretaries to Government, NITI Aayog leadership, senior bureaucrats, institutional investors, development finance institutions, and international agencies engaged with India's food and consumer policy ecosystem.

Chamber of Commerce and Industry (CCI India)

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About CCI India

CCI India (The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India) is a premier national business chamber dedicated to fostering economic growth, industry development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and investment promotion across India. As the voice of Indian business and industry, CCI India serves as a bridge between government, industry, startups, academia, investors, and civil society, facilitating meaningful collaboration for nation-building and sustainable development.

Through policy advocacy, business facilitation, research, stakeholder engagement, capacity building, and strategic partnerships, CCI India works to create an enabling environment for enterprises of all sizes. The Chamber actively supports key national initiatives such as Startup India, Make in India, Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Skill India, and Viksit Bharat 2047 by connecting innovative enterprises with government opportunities and promoting inclusive economic development.

CCI India operates through sector-specific councils, industry forums, knowledge platforms, and state-level engagements that address emerging opportunities and challenges across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology, healthcare, education, infrastructure, sustainability, MSMEs, and startups. The Chamber regularly organizes policy dialogues, investment summits, business delegations, workshops, conferences, and knowledge-sharing initiatives to strengthen India's economic ecosystem.

With a strong commitment to innovation, entrepreneurship, and public-private collaboration, CCI India strives to empower enterprises, facilitate investment, enhance competitiveness, and contribute to India's journey toward becoming a globally competitive and economically resilient nation. Its role as a knowledge partner and industry catalyst enables ministries, departments, state governments, startups, and businesses to collaborate effectively in achieving national development objectives.

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1: Introduction to the Ministry

Constitutional and Institutional Mandate

The Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution derives its authority from multiple constitutional provisions and parliamentary enactments. Under Entry 33 of the Concurrent List of the Seventh Schedule, Parliament holds concurrent legislative power over foodstuffs, including edible oilseeds and oils. The Directive Principles of State Policy particularly Article 39(b) and Article 47 obligate the State to ensure adequate nutrition and standard of living for all citizens. The Ministry operationalises these constitutional directives through two principal departments, each governing distinct but intersecting policy domains.

The Department of Food and Public Distribution is the institutional custodian of India's food security architecture. It administers the National Food Security Act, 2013, which is the most expansive entitlement programme in the world, covering approximately 67% of India's population. The Department manages the Central Pool of food grains, coordinates procurement through the Food Corporation of India (FCI) and State agencies, and oversees storage infrastructure with a capacity exceeding 80 million metric tonnes. It also regulates sugar production and distribution, administers import-export policies for food commodities, and oversees the buffer stocking policy.

The Department of Consumer Affairs operates under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, a landmark legislation that modernised India's consumer rights framework to address digital commerce, direct selling, e-commerce, and product liability. The Department administers the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS), the Legal Metrology Act through the Weights and Measures infrastructure, the Integrated Price Monitoring Cell, and the Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA). It also oversees commodity futures markets through the Forward Markets Commission's successor regulatory framework now vested in SEBI and the Food Safety Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) in coordination with the Ministry of Health.

Governance Role and National Significance

Few ministries in the Government of India have as direct and tangible an impact on the daily lives of ordinary citizens as MoCAFPD. The welfare of 813.5 million food subsidy beneficiaries, the protection of India's 1.4 billion consumers from adulteration, fraud, and exploitation, and the regulation of commodity markets that determine farm-gate and retail prices all fall within this Ministry's mandate. Its effective governance directly determines whether the poorest Indian households can afford their daily meals, whether the quality of goods purchased in markets meets safety standards, and whether farmers receive equitable prices for their produce. In this sense, the Ministry is both a social protection institution and an economic governance body.

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2: Historical Timeline of the Ministry

Table 2.1: Key Milestones in the Evolution of the Ministry

Year	Milestone	Strategic Significance
1943	Department of Food Established	Created during Bengal Famine to manage wartime food distribution; foundational moment for India's food governance infrastructure.
1964	Food Corporation of India (FCI) Founded	Established the institutional backbone for centralized procurement, storage, and distribution central to the Green Revolution's success in translating production gains into food security.
1986	Consumer Protection Act Enacted	India's first dedicated consumer rights legislation, establishing a three-tier quasi-judicial mechanism; a landmark in shifting governance from producer-centric to consumer-centric regulation.
1992	Targeted Public Distribution System (TPDS)	Shifted from universal to targeted distribution a paradigmatic policy reform to focus subsidies on below-poverty-line (BPL) households, improving fiscal efficiency.
2013	National Food Security Act (NFSA) Enacted	Transformed food subsidy from a welfare programme to a legal entitlement 75% of rural and 50% of urban populations entitled to subsidised grains at INR 1-3/kg. India's most consequential social legislation of the 21st century.
2016	One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC) Initiative	Enabled portability of food entitlements for migrant workers across states addressing a critical gap in food security for India's 450 million mobile workforce.
2019	Consumer Protection Act 2019	Replaced the 1986 Act; introduced e-commerce regulation, product liability provisions, Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA), and mediation mechanisms a generational upgrade of consumer rights governance.
2020	PMGKAY Launch	In response to COVID-19, the Government provided free food grains to 813.5 million beneficiaries demonstrating the Ministry's capacity to serve as a crisis-response social safety net at unprecedented scale.

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